The now mythical cricket World Cup win in 1983 casts a mystical light upon us Indians—a classic underdog-takes-the-trophy script we never tire of retelling. There was, though, a special never-say-die spirit about Kapil Dev's team from the very beginning: the convincing win over the redoubtable defending champions West Indies in the very first match was not just an aberration. From then on, it was a rollercoaster—a heavy loss against Australia, a win against Zimbabwe, a loss against the Windies, an overcoming of Zimbabwe that's the pedestal for Kapil's apotheosised 175 not out and a win against Australia. Thence, the famous win against England in the semis and the final slaying of Goliath. The Prudential Cup win is, of course, the meta cricket victory, for everything flowed from it: cricketers became icons, sponsorships flooded in and India, on the back of inspiring performances in following years (Sharjah, World Championship of Cricket, Reliance World Cup), emerged as a cricketing superpower. We still revel at the '83 heroes—Gavaskar, Kapil, Shivlal, Binny, Sandhu, Madan Lal, Srikkanth, Kirti Azad, Amarnath et al—playing some of their best cricket as a single unit. Even now, after a particularly galling sporting letdown, we go to bed with a warm consolation: we shall always have 1983. ■

THE 1983 WORLD CUP WIN ENSURED A SURGE IN POPULARITY FOR THE ONE-DAY GAME IN INDIA. CRICKETERS BECAME SUPERSTARS AND CORPORATE SPONSORSHIPS FLOWED INTO THE GAME



▲ **Miracle at Lord's**
July 15 1983

"The 50:1 odds that the London bookies offered against them had changed to 5:2 against an Indian win in the final. Even then, the possibility of India beating the formidable West Indies was wafer thin. The British media reflected that adequately.... But nobody at Lord's on that historic day could grudge India that glorious moment when Kapil lifted the glittering World Cup high into the air in triumph."

GETTY IMAGES





KAPIL DEV, *Former Indian cricket captain*

"At team meetings, I said, 'Give me 100 per cent'"

In 1983 in England, we were underdogs and no one gave us a chance. However, once you start winning, people change their minds. Starting in '83, people started recognising the team as one that could win consistently. As captain, I had to perform to the best of my ability and, importantly, to ensure that everybody plays like a team, to make them believe.

After winning the final against the West Indies, we were all delighted, to say the least. Actually, just making it to the final was good enough. At team meetings, I always said, "Give me 100 per cent." As captain, you want every player to be committed. Did the '83 win change the trajectory of Indian cricket? I honestly cannot tell, our job was to play. Even after 42 years, people tell me, "You are the one who changed the game." I don't think so. Undoubtedly, our victory was very, very important. The credit for that belongs to the team. India never won a match in the two previous World Cups in 1975 and 1979, except once, against East Africa. From there to come out and win the World Cup? INDIA TODAY got it right when they featured the win on its cover, calling it 'Miracle at Lord's'. I do think it was a miracle.

